

Make Remix Videos

With an Akai MPK mini

A beginner manual for Kiffness-style video remixes on Mac

MIDI -> DAW -> Instruments -> Mix -> Synced Video

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Codex with ChatGPT 5.5

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1 Start Here: What You Are Learning

You want to make videos in the spirit of The Kiffness: take a memorable source clip, find the musical hook inside it, and build a funny, tight, danceable arrangement around it. The Akai MPK mini is a good controller for learning this because it gives you keys, pads, knobs, and simple performance controls in one small desk instrument.

This manual assumes you are new to the MPK, MIDI, Mac audio, recording, mixing, syncing to video, and DAW workflow. It explains the pieces from zero and then turns them into a practice system.

The three reference videos for study are:

- The Shira Choir x The Kiffness - Im Hashem Lo Yivneh Bayis (Psalm 127 DANCE REMIX): <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=EGmXAu8geVg>
- The Kiffness - Ievan Polkka ft. Bilal Goregen (Club Remix): <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=CAyWN9ba9J8>
- The Kiffness x Ognjen & Sinisa - Insomnia (Balkan Club Remix): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=hVJtPuuQK_s

Respect copyright and permission. Use your own recordings, licensed samples, public-domain material, collaboration footage, or source clips you are allowed to remix. Learn the method, not unauthorized copying.

2 The Kiffness Method

The method is not “put a beat under a video.” It is closer to a musical reply. The source clip stays the star. Your job is to reveal the song hiding inside the clip.

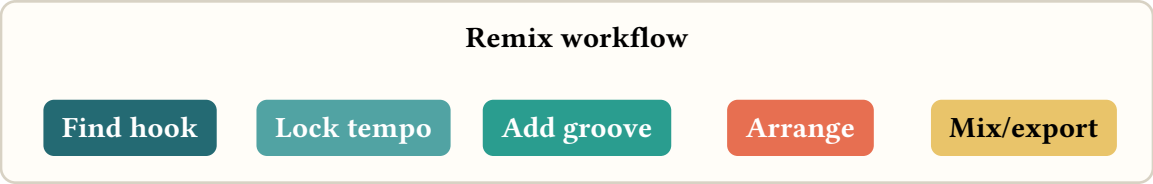


Figure 1: A source clip becomes a remix by moving from hook to tempo to groove to arrangement.

Watch the reference videos for these ingredients:

Ingredient	What to notice
Source hook	A voice, phrase, rhythm, or visual moment that is immediately recognizable.
Groove translation	Drums and bass make the source feel like a track.
Call and response	The source says something; the music answers.
Build and payoff	Layers enter in a way the viewer can follow.
Performance evidence	Hands, face, instruments, or DAW moments show the remix being made.

Your beginner goal is not to imitate every detail. Your goal is to finish short studies: 15 seconds, 30 seconds, then one minute.

3 What the MPK mini Is

The MPK mini is a MIDI controller. It usually does not make finished sound by itself. It sends instructions to software on your Mac: note on, note off, velocity, pad hit, knob movement, pitch bend, modulation, and timing features.

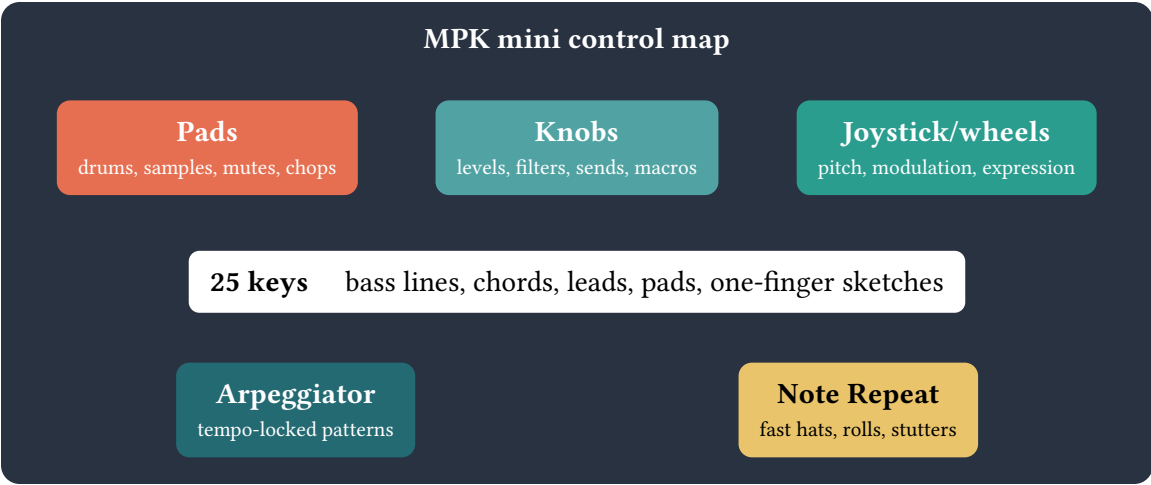


Figure 2: Treat the MPK as a performance surface for the DAW, not as the whole studio.

MPK part	What to use it for
Keys	Bass, chords, synth lines, piano parts, pads, and hooks.
Pads	Kick, snare, hats, percussion, samples, source chops, and transitions.
Knobs	Track volume, filter cutoff, reverb send, delay send, panning, and effect macros.
Joystick or wheels	Pitch bend, vibrato, filter movement, and expressive synth moments.
Arpeggiator	Rhythmic note patterns from held notes or chords.
Note Repeat	Repeated pad hits in time with the project tempo.

The most important beginner distinction: the MPK sends MIDI, while your DAW and plugins create audio.

4 MIDI and Audio Without Confusion

MIDI is control information. Audio is sound.

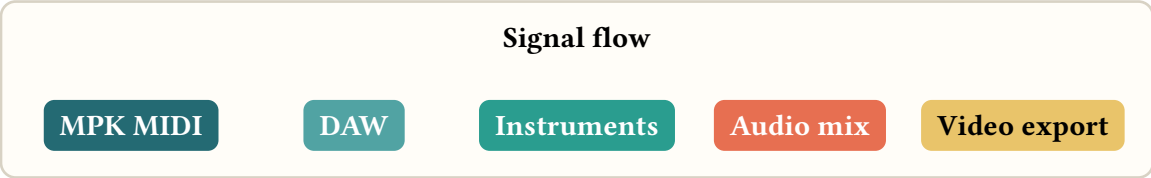


Figure 3: MIDI controls software instruments. Audio is recorded, mixed, and exported.

Term	Meaning
MIDI track	Editable instructions: notes, timing, velocity, knob movement.
Audio track	A recorded waveform: voice, guitar, source clip, or exported beat.
Instrument plugin	Software that turns MIDI into sound.
Effect plugin	Software that changes sound: EQ, compression, reverb, delay, saturation.
Latency	Delay between playing and hearing. Use wired headphones and low buffer settings.
Buffer size	Audio setting: small buffer for recording, larger buffer for mixing.

If you see MIDI notes but hear nothing, load an instrument. If you see an audio waveform but cannot change its notes, remember that it is already sound, not MIDI.

5 Mac Setup

Start simple. Do not buy ten things before you can make one loop.

1. Plug the MPK directly into the Mac over USB.
2. Open Audio MIDI Setup in Applications > Utilities and confirm the device appears.
3. Pick one DAW to start. This manual now treats GarageBand and FL Studio as the two main paths. GarageBand is easiest on Mac; FL Studio is stronger for pattern-based beat work and step sequencing.
4. Use wired headphones. Bluetooth latency will make timing feel broken.
5. Create a project folder with Source Video, Audio, Stems, Project, Exports, and Notes.

Gear	Recommendation
Built-in mic	OK for rough ideas, weak for final audio.
USB audio interface	Best next purchase for microphones, guitar, and lower-latency input.
Closed-back headphones	Prevent playback from leaking into a mic.
External monitor	Useful, not required. A laptop screen is enough for early projects.

6 Your Physical Rig: MPK, MOTU M4, Pre-73, and Mics

Your rig has two separate worlds:

- MIDI control: MPK mini to Mac over USB. This controls software instruments.
- Audio recording: microphones and preamps into the MOTU M4, then into GarageBand.

Keep those worlds separate in your head. The MPK does not plug into the MOTU for this workflow. The MPK plugs into the Mac. The MOTU handles audio.

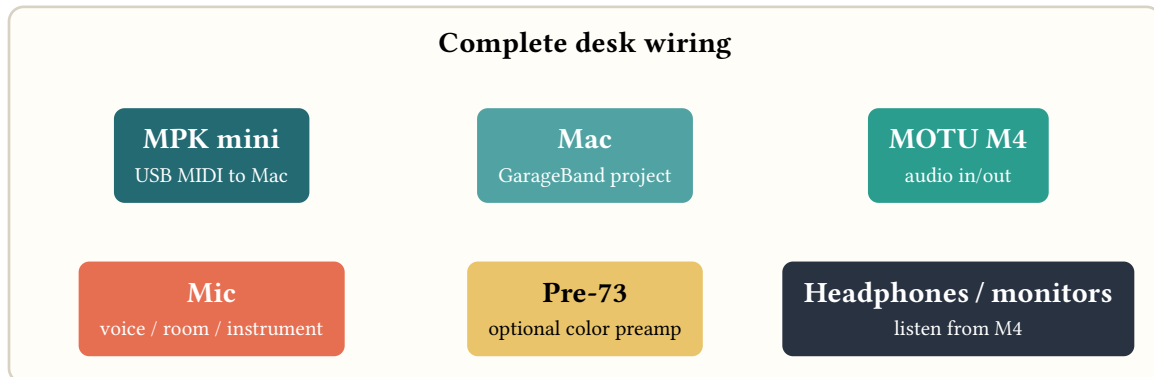


Figure 4: MIDI goes directly to the Mac; microphone audio goes through the M4.

6.1 Three Safe Connection Choices

Use case			Cable path	Phantom power
Condenser	mic	through	Mic XLR -> Pre-73 mic input -	Turn 48V on at the Pre-73.
	Pre-73		> Pre-73 line output -> MOTU	Keep MOTU 48V off.
			M4 rear line input 3 or 4	
Dynamic mic	through Pre-73		Mic XLR -> Pre-73 mic input -	Off, unless the mic specifi-
			> Pre-73 line output -> MOTU	cally requires phantom.
			M4 rear line input 3 or 4	
Mic directly into	MOTU		Mic XLR -> MOTU M4 front	Use M4 48V only for con-
			input 1 or 2	denser mics. Keep it off for
				dynamics/ribbons unless the
				mic manual says otherwise.

The Pre-73 is a preamp. If you use it, the cleanest beginner path is to send its line output into one of the M4 rear line inputs. That avoids running a preamp into another preamp. If you must use an M4 front combo input, keep the M4 gain low and watch the M4 meter carefully.

6.2 Power-Up and Power-Down Order

Use this order every time until it becomes boring.

1. Turn monitor speakers down or off. Put headphones on the table, not on your ears.
2. Confirm phantom power is off on the Pre-73 and M4.
3. Connect the mic.
4. Connect Pre-73 output to M4 line input if using the Pre-73.
5. Connect M4 to Mac over USB.
6. Open GarageBand and select the M4 as input and output.
7. Turn on phantom only if the mic needs it, and only on the device feeding the mic.
8. Bring gain up slowly while speaking or playing.

9. If anything clips red, turn down the earlier gain stage first.
10. Before unplugging a condenser mic, turn phantom off and wait about 10 seconds.

6.3 Gain Staging With the Pre-73 and M4

Gain staging means each device receives a strong signal without overload.

Stage	What to do	Watch
Pre-73 input gain	Raise until the mic feels present. More gain adds more preamp color.	Pre-73 meter should not live in overload.
Pre-73 output	Use it as the level sent to the M4. Lower output if you drove the input for color.	M4 input meter.
MOTU M4 line input	Prefer rear line input 3 or 4 for Pre-73 output.	Avoid red on the M4 meter.
GarageBand track	Arm the correct input and record.	Peaks around -12 dB to -6 dB are healthy.

For a clean vocal, use moderate Pre-73 gain and enough output to feed the M4. For a more colored vocal, raise Pre-73 gain and lower Pre-73 output so the M4 still receives a safe level.

6.4 Monitoring on the MOTU M4

The M4 can let you hear inputs directly, before GarageBand latency. Use direct monitoring when the delay bothers you while singing or playing.

Situation	Monitoring choice
Recording vocal through mic	Use M4 direct monitoring if GarageBand feels delayed.
Playing MPK software instrument	Monitor through GarageBand; MIDI instruments must be heard from the software.
Overdubbing voice over beat	Balance GarageBand playback and live input so both are comfortable.
Mixing	Turn direct monitoring off if it doubles the input sound.

7 Installing and Checking the MPK

The exact menus vary by software, but the pattern is the same: the Mac sees the MPK, the DAW enables it as a MIDI input, and an instrument track receives the notes.

7.1 GarageBand

1. Connect the MPK over USB.
2. Open GarageBand and create an empty project.
3. Choose Software Instrument.
4. Play the MPK keys. If you hear the selected instrument, the basic path is working.
5. Open GarageBand > Settings > Audio/MIDI if you need to refresh MIDI devices.

GarageBand is friendly for learning tracks, loops, software instruments, and basic recording. It is less ideal for advanced video sync and live performance mapping, but it is a good first week.

7.2 GarageBand With the MOTU M4

Use this as your first real setup checklist.

1. Connect the M4 to the Mac.
2. Connect headphones or monitors to the M4, not the Mac headphone jack.
3. Open GarageBand > Settings > Audio/MIDI.
4. Set Output Device to the MOTU M4.
5. Set Input Device to the MOTU M4.
6. Create an Empty Project.
7. For a mic, choose the Audio track with the microphone icon.
8. Open Details and choose the correct input:
 - Input 1 or 2 for M4 front mic inputs.
 - Input 3 or 4 for M4 rear line inputs fed by the Pre-73.
9. Enable “I want to hear my instrument as I play and record” only if you are not using M4 direct monitoring, or if you need to hear GarageBand effects.
10. Record a 10-second test and play it back before doing a full take.

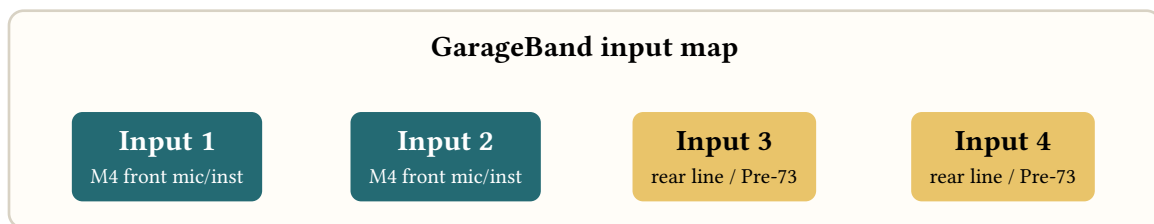


Figure 5: In GarageBand, M4 hardware inputs appear as selectable track inputs.

If the armed GarageBand track shows a meter but you hear nothing, check monitoring. If the M4 meter moves but GarageBand does not, the wrong track input is probably selected. If GarageBand records but playback comes from Mac speakers, the output device is not set to the M4.

7.3 FL Studio With the MPK and MOTU M4

FL Studio works well if you like patterns, drum grids, quick MIDI editing, and clip-style arranging. On Mac, treat the M4 as the audio device and the MPK as a MIDI input.

1. Connect the M4 to the Mac and connect headphones/monitors to the M4.
2. Connect the MPK mini to the Mac over USB.
3. Open FL Studio.

4. Open Options > Audio settings, or press F10 and choose the Audio tab.
5. In Input/output, select the MOTU M4/Core Audio device.
6. Set a small buffer for recording; raise it later if the project crackles.
7. Open Options > MIDI settings, or press F10 and choose MIDI.
8. In the Input list, select the MPK mini and enable it.
9. Confirm the MIDI activity light blinks when you play keys, pads, or knobs.
10. Add a Channel Rack instrument such as a drum plugin, sampler, FLEX, or a synth, then play the MPK.

For microphone recording in FL Studio on macOS, make sure macOS allows FL Studio to access the microphone/audio input. Then choose the correct M4 input on a Mixer insert before recording.

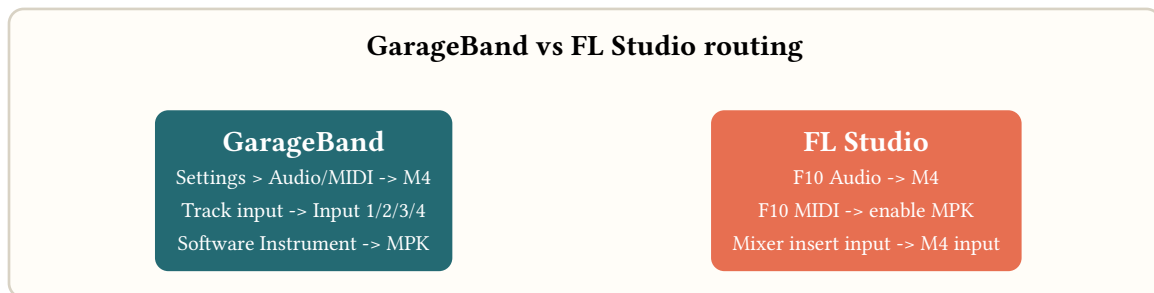


Figure 6: Both DAWs use the same hardware, but the setup screens are different.

7.4 GarageBand vs FL Studio: Which One for This Manual?

Task	GarageBand	FL Studio
First vocal or mic recording	Easier. Audio tracks are straightforward.	Works, but routing through Mixer inserts takes more setup.
MPK keys for piano/synth	Very easy with Software Instrument tracks.	Easy after MIDI input is enabled.
Finger-drummed beat	Good enough for learning.	Excellent with Channel Rack and patterns.
Pattern variations	More timeline-oriented.	Very strong: Pattern 1, Pattern 2, Pattern 3.
Knob automation	Possible through Smart Controls/automation.	Strong through linking controls and automation clips.
Video sync	Basic. Often finish video elsewhere.	Usually finish video elsewhere; export audio/stems.

Recommendation: start the mic/MOTU/Pre-73 setup in GarageBand because it is clearer. Build drum-pattern fluency in FL Studio because the Channel Rack makes pad sequencing feel natural. You can export stems from either DAW for video editing.

7.5 Logic Pro

Logic is the grown-up version of the GarageBand idea. Use it when you want better mixing, Flex Time, automation, video import, and export control.

1. Create a Software Instrument track.
2. Choose a drum kit, synth bass, piano, or sampler.
3. Press Record and capture MIDI from the MPK.
4. Use the Piano Roll to fix notes.
5. Use Smart Controls or MIDI Learn to assign knobs.

7.6 Ableton Live

Ableton is strong for looping, clips, warping, and performance. If your main goal is live building like a visible remix performance, Ableton is worth learning.

1. Enable the MPK as a MIDI input in Settings > Link/Tempo/MIDI.
2. Create a MIDI track with Drum Rack or an instrument.
3. Arm the track and play.
4. Use Session View for loops and Arrangement View for the final timeline.
5. Use Warp on source clips to lock them to tempo.

7.7 MPC Beats

Akai's setup path uses MPC Beats and the included software bundle. Akai's own setup article explains registration, the inMusic Software Center, installing MPC Beats, AIR plugins, sample packs, and enabling the MPK input. The key idea: the controller should appear in MIDI/Sync preferences, and its input should be enabled for track/control use.

Do one sanity test in every DAW: open one piano instrument and play the keys. If that works, the MPK is alive. Then test pads with a drum kit. Then test a knob with one visible parameter.

8 DAW Basics

A DAW has five zones: tracks, timeline, mixer, browser, and transport.

Zone	What it does
Tracks	One row per sound: source clip, drums, bass, chords, lead, voice, FX.
Timeline	Time moves left to right. Bars and beats organize the music.
Mixer	Volume, pan, mute, solo, sends, and plugins.
Browser	Instruments, samples, loops, presets, and files.
Transport	Play, stop, record, tempo, metronome, loop range.

Name tracks immediately. Kick, Snare, Source Clip, and Bass teach you more than Audio 1 and MIDI 7.

Save project versions:

- 01_import
- 02_tempo
- 03_drums
- 04_bass_chords
- 05_arrangement
- 06_mix
- 07_video_sync

9 Source Clip Preparation

The source clip is the heart of the remix. Spend more time choosing the right moment than choosing the snare sample.

Good source material has at least one of these:

- A phrase that repeats naturally.
- A rhythm you can tap with your hand.
- A melody that suggests a key.
- A funny, surprising, emotional, or beautiful visual.
- Space between phrases where your music can answer.

Avoid source clips where every second is dense. If the clip is already full of music, talking, crowd noise, and effects, it will be hard to add anything clean.

Practical source workflow:

1. Put the original file in Source Video.
2. Create a copy for editing, never your only original.
3. Extract or import the audio into the DAW.
4. Mark the best phrase.
5. Cut a two-bar or four-bar loop.
6. Add fades so the loop does not click.
7. Save a project version before warping.

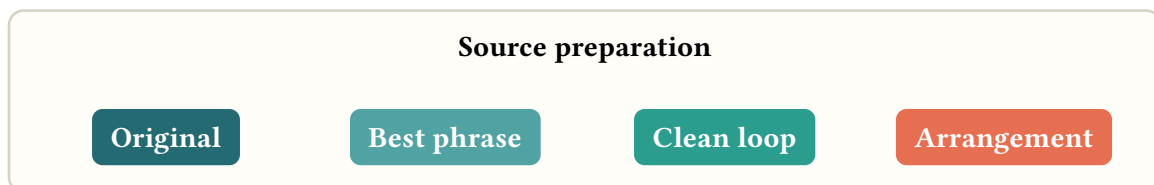


Figure 7: Prepare the source before writing extra parts.

10 MPK Mapping for Remix Work

Map only what you will actually touch during performance.

Control	Suggested beginner mapping
Pad 1	Kick
Pad 2	Snare or clap
Pad 3	Closed hi-hat
Pad 4	Open hi-hat
Pad 5	Percussion or shaker
Pad 6	Source clip chop
Pad 7	Transition hit
Pad 8	Crash, riser, or stop effect
Knob 1	Drum group volume
Knob 2	Bass volume
Knob 3	Chords volume
Knob 4	Lead volume
Knob 5	Filter cutoff
Knob 6	Reverb send
Knob 7	Delay send
Knob 8	Master/performance macro

Good mapping sentence: “I want my left hand to open the filter while my right hand plays the hook.” If you cannot say the sentence, do not map it yet.

10.1 Performance Knob Map

Use this as a stable performance map for the first month. You can change it later, but consistency will teach your hands where everything lives.

Knob	Assign to	Start position	Performance move
K1	Drum bus volume	75%	Pull down for source-only intro; push up at groove entrance.
K2	Bass volume	70%	Bring in after the source hook is understood.
K3	Chord/pad volume	50%	Fade up under emotional vocal notes.
K4	Lead/hook volume	60%	Lift only when answering the source phrase.
K5	Low-pass filter cut-off	35%	Open over 2 or 4 bars into a drop.
K6	Reverb send	10%	Momentary lift on final words or transition hits.
K7	Delay send	0%	Throw one word or stab into a break.
K8	Master performance macro	50%	Map later to a combined filter/saturation/width move.

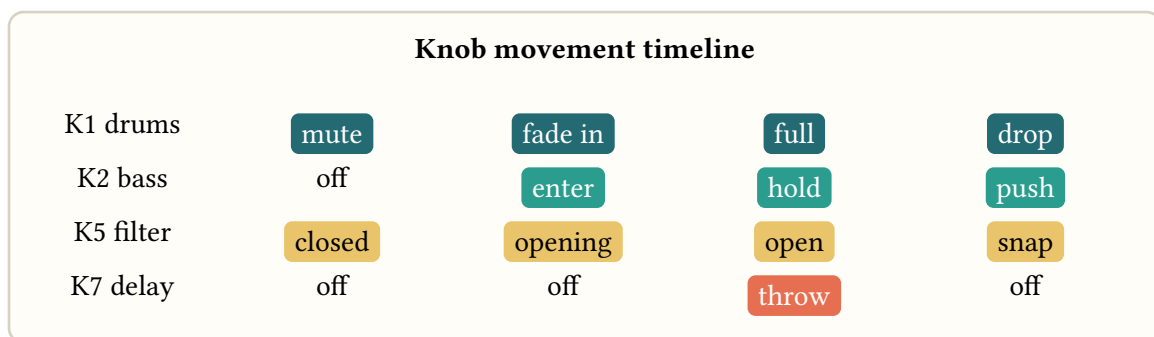


Figure 8: A simple four-section knob plan for intro, entrance, build, and drop.

11 Drum Programming on Pads

Finger drumming does not need to be flashy. For remix production, the goal is a reliable groove.

Start with this pad layout:

Pad	Sound	Why
1	Kick	Main pulse.
2	Snare	Backbeat.
3	Closed hat	Constant motion.
4	Open hat	Lift before changes.
5	Clap	Layer with snare for width.
6	Percussion	Style-specific flavor.
7	Crash	Section marker.
8	Vocal chop or hit	Source-related ear candy.

Record drums in layers instead of all at once:

1. Kick only.
2. Snare/clap.
3. Hats.
4. Percussion.
5. Fills.

This makes editing easier. It also teaches you which part is actually causing a timing problem.

11.1 Pad Timing Grid

Count a four-beat bar as “1 e and a 2 e and a 3 e and a 4 e and a”. Start with these hits:

Count	Pad	Sound
1	Pad 1	Kick
1 and	Pad 3	Closed hat
2	Pad 2	Snare or clap
2 and	Pad 3	Closed hat
3	Pad 1	Kick
3 and	Pad 3	Closed hat
4	Pad 2	Snare or clap
4 and	Pad 4	Open hat or lift

Once that is steady, add Pad 6 on the gap after a source phrase, not during the phrase. This keeps the source intelligible.

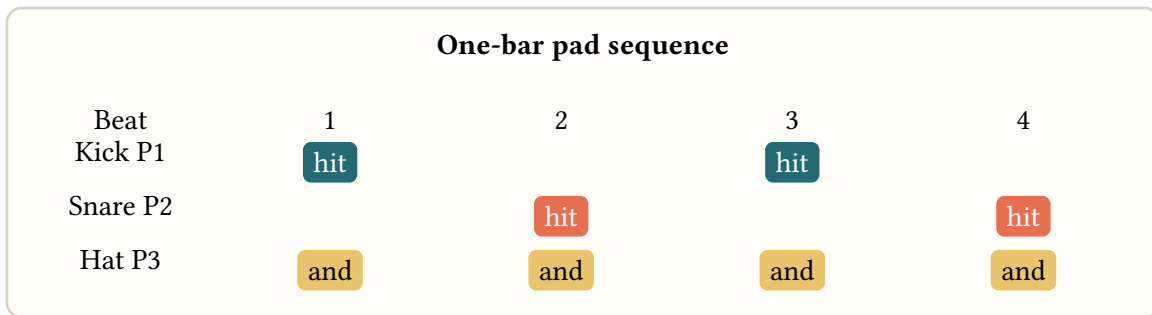


Figure 9: A first dance pattern using only three pads.

12 Playing Bass and Chords on Mini Keys

Mini keys are small, but they are enough for writing. Do not try to play like a concert pianist at first. Use them as a sketchpad.

For bass:

- Find the root note that sounds stable under the source phrase.
- Play fewer notes than you think.
- Make the bass agree with the kick.
- Use octave jumps for energy.
- Use passing notes only near the end of a bar.

For chords:

- Start with triads: major, minor, suspended.
- Hold chords under long vocal notes.
- Use short offbeat stabs for dance energy.
- If the source vocal is busy, use fewer chords.

When in doubt, play the root note in the bass and a simple minor or major chord above it. A simple correct part beats a clever crowded one.

13 A 16-Bar Remix Performance Sequence

This is the practical heart of the workflow. It tells you what to record or perform over 16 bars. Use it slowly at first, then make it musical.

Bars	Source/video	Pads	Keys	Knobs	Record/film
1-2	Source clip alone	None	None	K1 drums down, K5 filter closed	Show source premise.
3-4	Source loop repeats	P3 light hats only	Hold root note quietly	K3 chords low	Film listening/reaction.
5-8	Groove starts	P1 kick, P2 clap, P3 hats	Bass root/fifth pattern	K1 drums up, K2 bass up	Film MPK pads.
9-10	Source phrase re-turns	Keep beat simple	Chord pad under long words	K5 slowly opens	Film keys/knobs.
11-12	Build	Add P4 open hats, P7 riser/crash	Bass octave lift	K6 reverb slightly up	Film knob sweep.
13-16	Drop/payoff	Full pad pattern, P6 chop answer	Bass + hook answer	K5 open, K7 delay throw at bar 16	Film source + performance cuts.

13.1 Bar-by-Bar Beginner Script

Bar	Action
1	Press play on the source loop. Do not play yet. Let the viewer understand it.
2	Nod/count silently. Confirm the loop feels steady.
3	Tap Pad 3 hats on the offbeats. Keep them soft.
4	Add a quiet chord or bass root if the key is obvious.
5	Start Pad 1 kick on beats 1 and 3.
6	Add Pad 2 clap/snare on beats 2 and 4.
7	Add bass notes that line up with the kick.
8	Add a tiny fill with Pad 5 or Pad 6 at the end.
9	Bring source phrase back to the front. Do not overplay.
10	Turn K5 filter slowly upward.
11	Add open hat or shaker.
12	Turn K6 reverb up briefly on the last word.
13	Full drums, full bass, clear hook.
14	Play the answer phrase on keys.
15	Repeat the best musical idea, not a new one.
16	Use K7 delay throw, then stop or cut to source reaction.

The first time, record this as separate passes. Later, perform more of it live.

13.2 Where the Sequence Lives in Each DAW

Musical part	GarageBand place	FL Studio place
Source clip audio	Audio track on the timeline	Audio clip in Playlist or sampler/audio channel
Kick/snare/hats	Drum Kit Designer or sampler instrument track	Channel Rack drum channels or FPC
Bass	Software Instrument bass track	Channel Rack instrument routed to bass Mixer insert
Chords/pads	Software Instrument track	Instrument channel routed to chords/pad Mixer insert
Source chops	Sampler or audio regions	Slicer/Sampler/audio clips in Playlist
Knob filter move	Smart Control/track automation	Link controller to plugin/filter, record automation or create automation clip
Reverb/delay throw	Track send or plugin automation	Mixer send/effect automation clip
Final arrangement	GarageBand timeline	FL Studio Playlist

13.3 FL Studio Pattern Version of the 16 Bars

If you choose FL Studio, think in patterns first and Playlist arrangement second.

Pattern	Bars	Contains	Trigger/arrange
Pattern 1 - Hats	3-16	P3 closed hats, optional P4 open hat	Put under most of the source loop.
Pattern 2 - Core beat	5-16	P1 kick, P2 clap/snare, P3 hats	Enter when the groove starts.
Pattern 3 - Bass	5-16	Root/fifth bass notes from MPK keys	Route to bass Mixer insert.
Pattern 4 - Chords	9-16	Sustained chords or offbeat stabs	Fade or filter into build.
Pattern 5 - Fills/chops	8, 12, 16	P5/P6/P7 fills, source hit, crash	Drop only at section edges.
Automation clip - Filter	9-13	K5 low-pass opening	Draw or record curve into drop.
Automation clip - Delay	16	K7 delay send throw	One short moment, then back to zero.

In FL Studio, route drums, bass, chords, and source audio to separate Mixer inserts early. That makes the M4-recorded mic, the source clip, and the MPK instruments much easier to balance.

14 Rhythm, Tempo, and Sync

The source clip must agree with the project tempo. Even a comic remix needs a serious clock.

1. Import the source video or source audio.
2. Find the best two-bar or four-bar phrase.
3. Tap tempo while listening.
4. Loop the phrase against the metronome.
5. If it drifts, warp, flex, or slice the audio.
6. Build drums only after the source loop is stable.

Problem	Fix
Source rushes ahead	Add warp/flex markers or slice phrases to the grid.
Tempo feels wrong	Try half-time or double-time. 92 BPM may feel like 184 BPM.
Drums sound stiff	Use swing, velocity variation, and lighter quantization.
Loop clicks	Add tiny fades at region edges.

15 Quantization, Swing, and Human Feel

Quantization moves MIDI notes toward the grid. It can fix sloppy timing, but it can also remove personality.

Use these settings as a mindset:

Material	Quantize amount
Kick in club beat	Strong quantize is usually fine.
Snare/clap	Mostly tight, with small variation if desired.
Hi-hats	Quantize, then vary velocity.
Percussion	Lighter quantize; keep some human push/pull.
Bass	Tight to kick, but not robotic.
Chords	Depends on style; stabs can be tight, pads can be loose.
Source clip	Warp only as much as needed to make the groove work.

Swing shifts some subdivisions later, creating bounce. Try small swing amounts before you rewrite a pattern. If a groove feels technically correct but boring, vary velocity first, then try swing, then change notes.

16 Recording Instruments and Voice

Kiffness-style production often feels like one person building a tiny band around a clip.

Source	How to record it
MPK keys	Create an instrument track, choose a sound, arm, record MIDI.
MPK pads	Create a drum/sampler track, map pads, record MIDI hits.
Voice	Use a USB mic or audio interface; monitor with wired headphones.
Guitar or bass	Plug into an interface; record dry if you want to change amp sound later.
Percussion	Mic real claps/shakers or use samples. Real layers help programmed drums.

Record at healthy levels. Peaks around -12 dB to -6 dB are fine. If the waveform looks like a rectangle, it clipped; turn down the input and record again.

17 Microphones, Interfaces, and Monitoring

For voice, acoustic instruments, and room percussion, the recording chain is:

Voice/instrument -> microphone -> audio interface -> Mac/DAW -> headphones

If you use a USB microphone, the mic and interface are combined:

Voice/instrument -> USB microphone -> Mac/DAW -> headphones

Monitoring means hearing yourself while recording. If monitoring is delayed, you will play or sing late. Fixes:

- Use wired headphones.
- Lower the DAW buffer size while recording.
- Close CPU-heavy apps.
- Use direct monitoring on an audio interface when available.
- Record dry and add reverb after the take if latency is distracting.

Room noise matters. Turn off fans when possible. Stay close enough to the mic that your voice is stronger than the room.

18 Drums, Bass, Chords, and Hooks

Each layer has a job.

Layer	Job
Kick	Defines dance pulse.
Snare/clap	Gives the backbeat.
Hi-hats	Add motion and subdivision.
Percussion	Adds style and regional feel.
Bass	Connects drums to harmony.
Chords	Add emotion without crowding the source.
Lead/hook	Answers the source phrase.

Beginner two-bar pattern:

Beat:	1	2	3	4
Kick:	X		X	
Clap:		X		X
Hat:	x	x	x	x
Bass:	root		fifth	root

Start with drums and bass only. If that does not work, extra layers will not rescue it.

19 Arrangement Blueprint

A short remix still needs structure. Even 45 seconds can have a beginning, middle, and payoff.

Section	Length	Job
Cold open	2-5 seconds	Show the source premise immediately.
Setup loop	4-8 bars	Let the source hook repeat cleanly.
Groove entrance	4-8 bars	Add drums and bass.
Build	2-4 bars	Filter, riser, snare fill, or visual setup.
Drop/payoff	8-16 bars	Full remix energy.
Tag ending	1-4 bars	Punchline, delay throw, stop, or source reaction.

Kiffness-style videos often feel spontaneous, but the arrangement is doing real work. The viewer is being taught the source, shown the transformation, and then rewarded with the full version.

20 Mixing From Zero

Mixing is deciding what the listener should notice first, second, and third.

1. Pull every fader down.
2. Bring up the source clip or lead vocal until it is clear.
3. Add kick and bass.
4. Add snare/clap and hats.
5. Add chords and hook instruments.
6. Add reverb, delay, risers, and fills last.
7. Check on headphones and laptop speakers.

Tool	Beginner use
Volume	The main mix control. Use this before plugins.
Pan	Move support parts away from the center.
EQ	Remove mud and make room for voice.
Compression	Smooth levels or add punch. Use gently.
Reverb	Adds space. Too much pushes sounds away.
Delay	Rhythmic repeats, transition throws, endings.
Limiter	Prevents export clipping on the master.

Simple EQ starting point: high-pass non-bass instruments around 80 to 150 Hz, cut a little mud around 200 to 400 Hz if needed, and add presence around 2 to 5 kHz only when a sound needs clarity.

21 Effects That Make Remixes Feel Finished

Use effects as musical punctuation.

Effect	Use it for	Beginner warning
Filter sweep	Build into a drop or reveal a loop.	Do not leave every part filtered forever.
Reverb throw	Make one word or hit bloom.	Too much reverb makes the mix blurry.
Delay throw	Echo the last word before a break.	Time it to the project tempo.
Saturation	Add warmth and density.	Easy to overdo; compare before/after.
Sidechain compression	Make pads/bass pulse with kick.	Subtle is often better.
Riser/noise sweep	Signal a section change.	Keep it short in comedy or meme edits.

Record effect moves with knobs. A visible knob turn is both an audio event and a video event.

22 Syncing Music to Video

The picture should feel musical.

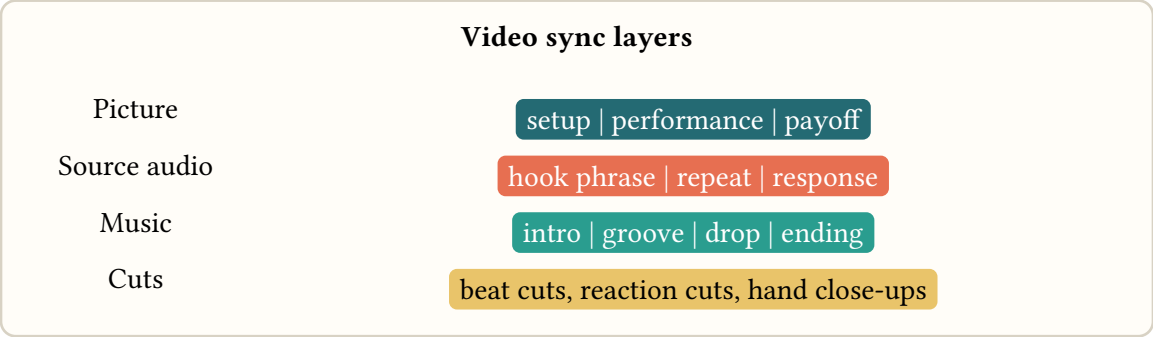


Figure 10: Treat the video edit as another rhythmic layer.

Use a clap, visible consonant, drum transient, or hand motion as a sync anchor. Cut to the source clip when it sings or speaks the hook. Cut to the MPK when a new layer enters. Export a short test before rendering the final version.

23 Export Settings

For learning, export often. Do not wait until a project is perfect before checking a render.

Audio export targets:

Use	Format
DAW mix for video editor	WAV or AIFF, 24-bit if available.
Quick sharing draft	MP3 or AAC.
Final video upload	Let the video editor encode audio with the video.

Video export targets:

Platform	Practical starting point
YouTube horizontal	1920 x 1080, 24/30 fps, H.264 or H.265.
Shorts/Reels/TikTok	1080 x 1920 vertical, 30 fps, H.264 or H.265.
Archive master	Highest quality your editor can reasonably store.

Always watch the exported file, not only the DAW timeline. Exports can reveal sync errors, missing fonts, muted tracks, clipping, and wrong aspect ratios.

24 Case Study: Im Hashem Lo Yivneh Bayis

This reference shows how a choir phrase can become the emotional center of a dance remix.

Element	Study notes
Source role	The choir provides the hook and harmonic identity.
Production goal	Support the vocal phrase with a dance pulse without burying the choir.
MPK use	Pads for drums, keys for bass/chords, knobs for filter and reverb build.
Practice version	Use your own sung phrase or a licensed choir-like sample.

Practice steps:

1. Choose a two-bar vocal or choir phrase with emotional lift.
2. Find the key by playing notes under it until one feels like home.
3. Program a four-on-the-floor kick.
4. Add clap/snare on beats 2 and 4.
5. Play a bass root on beat 1 and a passing note before beat 3.
6. Add warm chords under long syllables.
7. Open a filter or reverb send into the drop.

24.1 Choir Remix Pad/Knob Sequence

Bars	Pads	Keys	Knobs	Goal
1-2	None	Find and hold root quietly	K1 down, K3 low	Let the choir be the hook.
3-4	P3 hats only	Soft chord pad	K3 fade up	Add lift without stealing focus.
5-8	P1 four-on-floor, P2 clap	Bass on root and fifth	K1 and K2 up	Convert choir phrase into dance pulse.
9-12	Add P5 shaker	Chord inversions	K5 opens slowly	Build anticipation.
13-16	P7 crash at bar 13, P6 vocal chop answer	Hook answer melody	K6 reverb on final syllable	Payoff and emotional bloom.
17	Stop drums	None	K7 delay throw	Let the last choir word echo.

For choir-like material, reverb is tempting. Use it as a moment, not as fog. The source already has space and harmony; your mix should preserve the words.

25 Case Study: Ievan Polkka

This reference is a strong study in turning a viral performance into a club arrangement.

Element	Study notes
Source role	The melody and performance personality are already strong.
Production goal	Make the source danceable without losing its playful identity.
MPK use	Pads for kick/snare/hat, keys for bass, note repeat for hats, knobs for delay throws.
Practice version	Use a public-domain folk melody or your own whistled phrase.

Fast folk melodies often work over a simpler club foundation. Do not make every part busy. Use bass to translate the melody into dance music. Place percussion fills in the gaps between phrases.

25.1 Folk/Club Remix Pad/Knob Sequence

Bars	Pads	Keys	Knobs	Goal
1-2	None	None	K1 down	Let the source melody introduce itself.
3-4	P3 hats with Note Repeat	Root pulse	K5 half closed	Hint at tempo.
5-8	P1 kick, P2 clap, P3 hats	Root-fifth-octave bass	K1/K2 up	Make it club-readable.
9-12	P5 percussion between phrases	Short chord stabs	K7 tiny delay on phrase endings	Keep motion playful.
13-16	P4 open hat, P7 crash	Bass octaves	K5 opens, K8 macro up	Drop without crowding the melody.
17-20	P6 source chop answer	Simple lead response	K7 delay throw at the end	Turn the source into call-and-response.

If the melody is fast, your hands should play less. Let the source do the gymnastics while the MPK supplies weight and shape.

26 Case Study: Insomnia

This reference points toward live-looping energy: build the track in visible layers so viewers can feel each entrance.

Element	Study notes
Source role	The Balkan musical character supplies rhythm, melodic flavor, and visual identity.
Production goal	Layer club drums under regional rhythm without flattening the feel.
MPK use	Pads for layered percussion, keys for stabs and bass, knobs for buildup effects.
Practice version	Record claps, a short vocal phrase, or a hand-played melody.

Lock the downbeat, but do not destroy all timing personality. Some music feels right because it leans ahead or relaxes behind the grid.

26.1 Balkan/Live-Loop Pad/Knob Sequence

Bars	Pads	Keys	Knobs	Goal
1-2	P5 hand percussion only	None	K1 low	Establish human rhythm.
3-4	Add P1 kick under percussion	Root drone	K2 barely up	Lock the downbeat.
5-8	P2 clap/snare, P3 hats	Offbeat chord stabs	K3 up	Blend club pulse with regional feel.
9-12	P6 source hit in gaps	Bass answer phrase	K5 opens	Build the loop visibly.
13-16	P4 open hat, P7 crash	Full bass + stabs	K6 small reverb lift	Full loop payoff.
17-20	Strip back to P5 then re-enter	Short lead answer	K7 delay throw	Create a break and return.

For this style, avoid quantizing every percussion hit to perfection. Keep the kick reliable, then let supporting percussion breathe.

27 Live Looping and Performance Capture

Even if the final video is edited, practice live looping because it teaches fast decisions.

Loop layer	Performance tip
Drum loop	Record two bars; quantize lightly.
Bass loop	Keep it short and repeatable.
Chord loop	Use long notes or offbeat stabs.
Hook answer	Play a tiny phrase that comments on the source.
FX pass	Record knob movement after the notes are solid.

Film hands, face, source clip, and DAW separately if needed. Record audio directly in the DAW, not through the camera mic.

28 Video Editing for Music Producers

Your edit should prove that the music is interacting with the source.

Shot	Purpose
Source clip	Shows the premise.
MPK close-up	Shows pads, keys, and knob moves creating musical events.
DAW screen	Optional proof of layering. Use sparingly.
Face/performance	Adds reaction and humor.
Wide desk shot	Establishes the real setup.

The first five seconds matter. Make the premise obvious, then let the musical build carry the rest.

29 Copyright, Collaboration, and Credits

Remix culture thrives on reference and transformation, but public uploads can still run into copyright claims, takedowns, or blocked monetization.

Safer source choices:

- Your own videos and recordings.
- A friend's clip used with written permission.
- Public-domain recordings.
- Creative Commons material where the license allows remixing.
- Paid sample packs and licensed loops.

Good credit habits:

- Keep source URLs and permission notes in the project folder.
- Credit collaborators clearly.
- Do not imply endorsement by the original creator.
- If someone asks you to remove their clip, take the request seriously.

For practice, you can make private remixes that never leave your computer. For public release, think like both a musician and a publisher.

30 Practice Projects

Project	Goal
One phrase, one beat	Take a legal two-bar phrase and build drums only.
Bass translation	Add a bass line that makes the phrase feel like a song.
Knob performance	Map filter and reverb, then record automation.
Live layer video	Film yourself adding drums, bass, and chords.
Full remix sketch	Make a 45-second intro, drop, break, and ending.

Four-week plan:

- Week 1: MPK, MIDI, tempo, tracks, and simple drums.
- Week 2: three 15-second remixes from your own voice memos.
- Week 3: video sync and camera angles.
- Week 4: one finished 45 to 60 second remix.

31 Troubleshooting

Symptom	Likely fix
MPK not detected	Try another USB cable/port, avoid hubs, check Audio MIDI Setup, restart DAW.
Keys move meters but no sound	Load an instrument plugin and enable monitoring.
Pads trigger wrong sounds	Load the correct kit or remap pad notes.
Delay while playing	Use wired headphones, lower buffer size, close heavy apps.
Audio distorted	Lower input gain and record again.
Video drifts	Check tempo, warp/flex settings, frame rate, and variable-frame-rate source files.
Export too quiet	Balance the mix, use a limiter, compare at matched volume.

Before panic: create a new empty project with one software piano track. If the MPK plays that, the controller is fine and the problem is inside the original session.

32 Quick Reference

Task	Fast path
Start project	Create folder, import source clip, save version 01_import.
Find tempo	Tap tempo, loop source phrase, align to grid.
Build groove	Kick, clap, hat, bass. Stop before decoration.
Map MPK	Pads to drums; knobs to levels/filter/reverb/delay.
Record	Arm track, count-in, loop section, record multiple takes.
Mix	Balance source, drums, bass, chords, hooks, FX, limiter.
Sync video	Align source audio, cut to beats, export test.
Finish	Listen on headphones and laptop, fix, export final.

33 Sources and Further Learning

Primary reference videos:

- <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=EGmXAu8geVg>
- <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=CAyWN9ba9J8>
- https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=hVJtPuuQK_s

Akai references used for setup and controller behavior:

- Akai MPK mini MK3 product page: <https://www.akaipro.com/mpk-mini-mk3/>
- Akai MPK mini setup article: <https://support.akaipro.com/en/support/solutions/articles/69000798879-akai-pro-mpk-mini-mpk-mini-play-mpk-mini-plus-how-to-download-install-and-setup-the-included-so>
- Akai MPK mini Plus user guide: <https://cdn.inmusicbrands.com/akai/attachments/mpkminiplus/MPK%20mini%20Plus%20-%20User%20Guide%20-%20v1.2.pdf>

Hardware and DAW references used for the expanded setup:

- Apple Audio MIDI Setup for Mac: <https://support.apple.com/guide/audio-midi-setup/set-up-audio-devices-ams59f301fda/mac>
- Apple MIDI Studio setup for Mac: <https://support.apple.com/guide/audio-midi-setup/set-up-midi-devices-ams875bae1e0/mac>
- MOTU M4 product page: <https://motu.com/products/m-series/m4>
- MOTU M4 specifications: <https://motu.com/en-us/products/m-series/m4/specs/>

- Golden Age Audio Pre-73 MKIII: <https://goldenageaudio.com/outboard-hardware/preamps/pre-73-mk-iii/>
- Golden Age Project PRE-73 MKIII manual: https://goldenagemusic.se/home/goldenageproject/manuals/manual_pre73mk3.pdf
- FL Studio audio setup: https://www.image-line.com/fl-studio-learning/fl-studio-online-manual/html/app_wiz2.htm
- FL Studio audio settings: https://www.image-line.com/fl-studio-learning/fl-studio-online-manual/html/envsettings_audio.htm
- FL Studio MIDI settings: https://www.image-line.com/fl-studio-learning/fl-studio-online-manual/html/envsettings_midi.htm
- FL Studio audio recording: https://www.image-line.com/fl-studio-learning/fl-studio-online-manual/html/recording_audio.htm

Search terms for deeper study:

- GarageBand MIDI controller setup
- FL Studio MIDI settings MPK mini
- FL Studio audio recording MOTU M4
- Logic Pro Flex Time vocals
- Ableton Live warp audio to tempo
- MPC Beats MPK mini mapping
- DaVinci Resolve audio sync
- beginner EQ compression reverb delay